

plans. The Bayshore freeway flooded and I was stuck in traffic for four hours. Instead of watching football games and laughing with my brother, I was sitting in a steamy car surrounded by fumes, noise, and irate drivers.

By the time I got home my brother had come and gone. I took three aspirin and went to bed. The next day Vicki and I decided to see if we could live without a car. We stuck the car in the garage and told ourselves we would drive it only if desperate.

We began to use buses, taxis, trains, and our feet to get around San Francisco. For longer trips we rode with others or, once or twice a year, rented a car. About that time the first OPEC crisis began to show at the pump. We watched people wait for hours to buy gas. We never waited in lines because we never needed gas. We began to feel a bit smug.

Six months later we still hadn't needed any gas. That's when we got a big insurance bill. Rather than pay it, we sold the car. And in over ten years we've never been tempted to buy another one.

Think about cars in your life. If you're like me, both parents had cars when you grew up. As far back as you can remember, you spent interminable hours riding and waiting in a car. As each member of the family turned 16, he got a license and then a car. Conversation around the dinner table soon centered on fender benders, gas prices, repairs, and buying and selling.

By the time you were 25 or so you had crashed and traded up a couple of times. In your short driving career you had spent a small fortune on gas, tires, insurance, repairs, tickets, parking, and fines. That was bad enough. But then things got really expensive. Gas prices per gallon went from 30 cents to over a dollar. A few years later Detroit managed to get Congress to limit imports. That gave GM, Ford, and Chrysler a free hand to jack up prices.

According to Hertz there are 42 million trucks and 129 million cars in America today. It costs 33 cents a mile to own